the CIA, and the émigrés themselves, assumed that he would (despite everything he said). There was also one other factor that could have changed – indeed transformed – the prospect of success: the death of Fidel Castro (and elimination of other key figures in the government).

Terminating with extreme prejudice

Soon after Kennedy's inauguration, the CIA was tasked with developing an 'Executive Action Programme' designed to target and, if necessary, assassinate foreign leaders. In fact, under the Eisenhower administration, the CIA was already busy plotting to kill Castro. Outside the agency (indeed in some places within it) these plans were hugely controversial, and for critics (at home and abroad), morally unacceptable. They were, of course, wholly incompatible with the inspiring rhetoric of John F. Kennedy, which continued (and continues) to animate many in the United States. In November 1961 Kennedy solemnly told students at the University of Washington, 'We cannot, as a free nation, compete with our adversaries in tactics of terror, assassination, false promises, counterfeit mobs, and crises.'[56] The reality was that CIA was extremely competitive in the dark arts of the secret world.

In the 1970s the United States Congress investigated the agency. The Senate Select Committee to Study Governmental Operations with Respect to Intelligence Activities scrutinised CIA's involvement in 'alleged assassination attempts' against foreign leaders. These included those against Rafael Trujillo of the Dominican Republic and Patrice Lumumba in the Congo. In 1975 the committee, chaired by Senator Frank Church, learned that CIA assassination planning against Fidel Castro, included, 'high-powered rifles … poison pills, poison pens [and] deadly bacterial powders.'[57] The Church Committee 'found concrete evidence' of at least eight plots to assassinate Castro involving the CIA from 1960 to 1965. The former head of Cuban State Security, Fabian Escalante, later wrote that there were 612 documented plots against Castro between 1959 and 1993 (though many of these were attributable to plotters outside CIA).[58]